Openhearted, Not Unguarded

Building Healthy Connections in Recovery

Recovery depends on connection, trust, and vulnerability. Everyone deserves to feel welcome, respected, and safe participating in our fellowship.

Not everyone will treat others with the care they deserve. Harm can take many forms, from discrimination and unwanted attention to manipulation, harassment, and exploitation.

We can be openhearted without being unguarded.

Safety isn't only about responding when something goes wrong. It's also about building the connections, judgment, and resilience that help us navigate relationships without losing our connection to recovery.

Resilience isn't about closing ourselves off. It's developing the relationships and capacities that make vulnerability sustainable.

Four Principles for Navigating Relationships in Recovery

1. Build connections. Develop a broad support network so your recovery doesn't depend on any one relationship.

2. Practice discernment. Notice how feelings, needs, old patterns, and other people's influence shape your choices. Examine your assumptions and give yourself room to respond.

3. Respect autonomy. Your needs and boundaries matter, as do everyone else's. Notice what is shaping your choices. Respect others' choices and take care with how you influence them.

4. Seek support. Draw on others for perspective, help, and connection. Don't let difficult experiences become isolating experiences.

1. Build a Broad Support Network

Build connections with more than one person, at a pace that works for you. Get to know people in different parts of the fellowship, so your support doesn't depend on any one person or circle. You don't have to share everything with anyone.

A difficult or harmful experience with one person needn't become your whole experience of recovery.

Putting the Principles into Practice

2. Practice Discernment

Some of us have learned to see danger everywhere; others have learned to overlook danger, even when it's right in front of us. Most of us do some of both.

Where you're frequently alarmed, practice distinguishing discomfort from danger. Where you've learned to suppress discomfort, practice recognizing when something may be wrong even when everything seems fine.

Neither your feelings nor their absence tells the whole story. Notice your reactions, or lack of reactions, without automatically accepting or dismissing them.

Notice what feels especially rewarding, too. Attention, affection, validation, and belonging can shape our judgment. Something can feel good without being good for us.

Look at what's happening. Ask yourself: *What happened? What am I assuming it means? What do I need?*

Consider four dimensions of your choices:

Freedom. Can I express what I want, disagree, slow down, say no, or change my mind? What makes those choices feel too easy or difficult?

Stakes. What would I feel I'd *risk* by saying no? Might I face anger, or lose affection, approval, belonging, or practical support? What makes me expect that consequence?

Drives. What old patterns or present needs might be shaping my response? Is attention, reassurance, attraction, or belonging changing what I'm willing to overlook, accept, or do?

Influence. How is this connection shaping what I want and expect? Do I understand what the other person wants and is offering, as well as how their attention makes me feel?

Notice not only how a relationship feels in the moment, but how it affects your wellbeing, freedom, and connection over time.

Give yourself time, consider whether your boundaries are respected, and seek perspective from people you trust. **You don't have to reject a feeling to examine it, or act on it simply because it feels compelling.**

3. Respect Boundaries, Including Your Own

Vulnerability isn't an invitation to romantic or sexual attention. You never owe anyone personal information, intimacy, or continued contact.

You can say no, change your mind, or disengage without owing anyone an explanation.

You can also ask for what you need, and others can be honest about what they can offer.

Notice what you're seeking from others. Are you considering the other person's wellbeing as well as your own? Your needs and desires are legitimate, but they don't obligate anyone else. Healthy connection respects everyone's freedom to choose.

Others have that same freedom. Respect their choices without demanding explanations or pressuring them to reconsider. You can acknowledge your own disappointment without assuming what their decision means about you.

3. Respect Boundaries, Including Your Own (continued)

Mind your influence. Differences in experience, confidence, recovery, or social standing can give us considerable influence over others. The more influence we have, the greater our responsibility to exercise it with care.

You can't ultimately control another person's feelings, but you are responsible for how you use your influence. **Greater experience calls for greater care, not greater authority over someone else's choices.**

Consider the same four dimensions from the other side:

Freedom. Am I leaving room for the other person to want something different, set the pace, say no, or change their mind? Can they do so without being pressed to reassure me or justify themselves?

Stakes. What might this person feel they risk by disappointing me? Am I using their attachment, gratitude, admiration, or reliance on me as leverage?

Drives. What am I trying to satisfy through this interaction? Am I making someone else responsible for my reassurance, self-worth, gratification, or sense of control?

Influence. What can I anticipate, because of my experience or position, that they may not? Am I being clear about what I want and can offer, or relying on their misunderstanding, trust, or vulnerability to get the response I want?

Good intentions don't guarantee a welcome impact, and a welcome response doesn't settle whether we're treating someone well. Respect signs that your attention isn't wanted, while also considering how you are cultivating trust, attachment, and expectations.

Be honest about what you want and can offer. Leave room for time, questions, other relationships, and outside perspectives. Be willing to change course, including when the attention you are receiving feels good.

4. Reach Out and Speak Up

Whether something feels wrong or you simply want another perspective, talk it over with someone you trust, whether a friend, sponsor, or group trusted servant.

You can seek perspective on how someone is treating you, how you are treating them, or a pattern developing between you. You don't need to be certain that anyone has done something wrong before seeking support.

If you notice behavior that concerns you, even when you're not directly involved, you can seek perspective or speak with a trusted servant. You don't need to establish someone's intentions or prove wrongdoing before raising a concern.

How we respond to concerns matters not only for safety, but for everyone's opportunity to recover.

4. Reach Out and Speak Up (continued)

Observe behavior without taking someone else's inventory. Describe what you saw or heard and what concerns you. Distinguish observations from interpretations, without diagnosing character defects, assigning motives, or deciding what kind of person someone is. We can take behavior seriously without reducing someone to their behavior.

Offer a mirror, not a verdict. When appropriate, we can reflect what we've observed, listen to the other person's perspective, and invite them to consider the effects of their behavior. We can't work someone else's program, but sometimes a compassionate reflection helps someone recognize a pattern and choose differently. We don't have to convince them, correct them, or take responsibility for what they do with that perspective.

Seek help, not an audience. Raising a concern can be an act of care. Ask yourself: *Am I seeking perspective, offering support, or protecting someone, or am I recruiting people to take sides?* When concerns become gossip or judgments about someone's character, we risk isolating people from the very community where they're trying to heal and grow. Share relevant concerns with care and discretion, involving people who can offer support or help address them.

Discretion isn't silence. We can respect someone's dignity and opportunity for recovery while taking harmful behavior seriously. Sometimes that means a private conversation; sometimes it means involving trusted servants or taking protective action. Nobody is obligated to confront someone who has harmed them, and protecting others may require speaking more widely when appropriate.

You don't have to determine someone's motives before deciding to pause, decline, seek support, or leave.

Sometimes the next step is setting a boundary, sometimes it's disengaging, sometimes it's working through discomfort, and sometimes it's asking for help addressing harmful behavior.

As you learn more, you can change your understanding or choose a different response.

If someone crosses your boundaries, you are not alone, and you are not to blame for their behavior. You deserve support even if you didn't recognize the problem, found it hard to say no, or are still unsure what happened.

Staying connected to recovery doesn't require staying in a relationship or meeting that harms you.

You don't have to navigate difficult experiences alone. Reach out. Connection is part of recovery.

Safety and Our Primary Purpose

MA's Safety Card complements these principles with guidance for recognizing safety concerns, seeking support, and helping groups maintain safe, welcoming meetings.

MA Safety Card: MA12.org/safetycard

Guided by Traditions Three and Five, our goal isn't to judge who's worthy of recovery. It's to foster a community where everyone has the opportunity to pursue it, even when some of us are still sick and suffering.

Everyone deserves a chance at recovery. Everyone deserves to feel safe seeking it.

An independent, member-created resource for navigating relationships in recovery. Not an official publication of Marijuana Anonymous.